CREW PROFILE

GALLEON

1550–1650

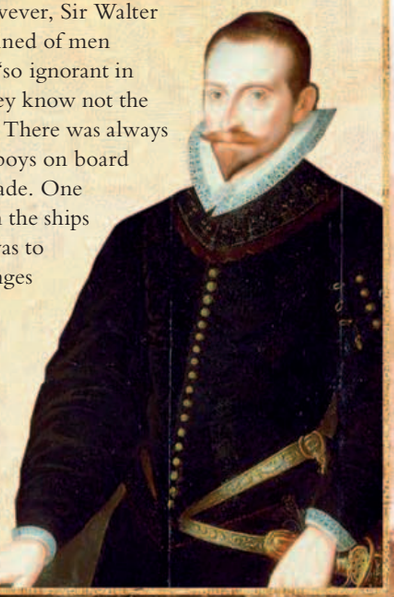
A LATE 16TH-CENTURY GALLEON might typically have 200 to 300 men on board. The normal social hierarchy continued to function at sea, with those of higher standing relatively privileged, but life aboard was hard for everyone. Men slept on the wooden deck unless they had brought their own bed with them—hammocks were not yet in common use and no specific areas were designated for sleeping. Food was often poor due to storage problems, and beer, wine, and water was sometimes sour and undrinkable. Outbreaks of disease were a constant threat, taking a heavy toll of galleon crews at all times. Pay was low and uncertain, but there was always the chance the crew might profit from seizing a prize.

CAPTAIN AND OFFICERS

The captain of a galleon would be at least a gentleman and often a nobleman. Many were experienced soldiers but in no sense men of the sea. In the Spanish navy the captain might be supported by a hierarchy of commissioned officers, but on board an English galleon he held command alone. The only other officer on board was likely to be the commander of the body of soldiers carried in the forecastle. The captain's only social equals on board were likely to be gentleman adventurers who pressed forward to serve in pursuit of glory. Regarded as rank amateurs who drove admirals to despair, many were nonetheless taken on board with varying degrees of usefulness.

PROFESSIONAL SEAMEN

The captain was not necessarily expected to know anything about sailing a ship, a job which fell to his most important subordinate, the master, an experienced mariner, along with the pilot and the boatswain. The bulk of the crew—some of them volunteers but most pressed into service—were in theory experienced seamen. The Spanish used convicts to row galleys but not to man galleons. Crew were taken in time of war from the population of fishermen, merchant seamen, and privateers in port towns. However, Sir Walter Raleigh complained of men being taken on "so ignorant in sea service, as they know not the name of a rope." There was always a flock of ship's boys on board learning their trade. One of their duties on the ships of the Armada was to sing out the changes of the watch.



Sir James Lancaster
A typical captain of the era, Lancaster was part merchant, part privateer. In 1588 he commanded an armed merchantman in the battle against the Armada.

ANGLO-SPANISH WARS



DEFEAT OF SPANISH ARMADA

Date	July 29–August 12, 1588
Location	Seas around the British Isles
Result	English victory

COMBATANTS

ENGLAND	SPAIN

COMMANDERS

Lord Howard of Effingham	Duke of Medina Sidonia

FORCES

Ships: 197 galleons and armed merchantmen	**Ships:** 130, including 22 galleons, 4 galleasses

LOSSES

Men: c.400 **Ships:** none	**Men:** c.2,000 in battle **Ships:** 6 in battle, 57 on voyage back to Spain

The crucial battle
There were a number of small engagements as the English ships followed the Armada up the Channel. The fleets did not fully engage until the Spanish reached Calais, when the English launched a full-scale attack.